

STONE AND BONE WEAPONS

The first human tools were made of stone, bone, or wood. The earliest were simple pebble choppers and scrapers, but by around 1.75 million years ago, these had developed into the first hand axes – shaped blades – which could be gripped firmly in the hand to strike an enemy. Gradually, the blades became narrower and sharper, most often made of flint, a stone that was hard but could be easily shaped. Wooden shafts were bound to sharp blades to form axes and spears, and eventually – with the invention of the bow – to act as arrowheads, vastly extending the range at which the warrior could attack. Most early stone weapons were made with multiple uses in mind, from domestic tasks to hunting, as well as warfare.

▼ STONE AXEHEAD

Date 4000–2000BCE

Origin UK

Length 20cm (8in)

Adding wooden handles gave axes greater reach and power, enabling the bearer to attack from a safer distance. This stone axehead was dredged from the River Thames in London.



▼ OLDUVAI CHOPPER

Date Up to 2.5 million years ago

Origin Africa

Length Unknown

Olduvai tools are amongst the oldest known deliberately shaped objects, first appearing around 2.5 million years ago. Choppers such as this were versatile tools, used as cutting edges, scrapers, and for bludgeoning prey.



Sharp edge for cutting

► FLINT HAND DAGGER

Date c.2000BCE

Origin Unknown

Length 30cm (12in)

The addition of wooden shafts to flint blades, bound with sinew or leather strips, created stabbing spears, and allowed the bearer to use the full force of his arm to strike blows.



Wooden shaft

▼ ATLATL

Date c.10,500BCE

Origin France

Length Unknown

Atlatls, or spear throwers, were developed around 20,000 years ago. They increased a spear's velocity and range, which allowed the bearer to kill prey from a greater distance. This reindeer-ivory example is carved as a mammoth.



Spear lay flat along mammoth's back

Stylized mammoth tusk

Handle in shape of mammoth legs

▼ FLINT ARROWHEADS

Date c.2700–1800BCE

Origin Unknown

Length 5cm (2in)

The invention of the bow during the Paleolithic period made it possible to shoot projectiles at great range and with accuracy. As these flint arrowheads were barbed, they embedded themselves deep in the victim's flesh.



Tang to attach arrowhead to shaft

Triangular point

▼ SERRATED FLINT KNIFE

Date 1,500,000–10,000BCE

Origin Unknown

Length 20cm (8in)

Serrated edges were developed for sawing through bone or other tough materials. However, the jagged flint edges on this knife could also inflict savage cuts.

Serrated teeth for sawing

